Seeing the Choice: Re’eh, the Soul’s Portion, and the Sanctification of the Month on 21 Av

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Parshat Re’eh (Devarim 12:29–13:19), Tehillim 104–105, Tanya Iggeret HaKodesh beginning of Epistle 7, Rambam Hilchot Kiddush HaChodesh Chapter 5, Hayom Yom of Menachem Av 21, and the Daily Thought “De-Victimizing”

The daily learning cycle of Av 21, 5786 presents not a collection of discrete texts but a single, densely interwoven demand upon the human being. That demand is the active exercise of sight and choice within a covenantal order that is neither arbitrary nor indifferent to the capacities already latent in the soul. The third aliyah of Parshat Re’eh opens with the warning that follows conquest: when the Lord your G-d cuts off the nations before you and you settle in their land, beware lest you be ensnared into following them, inquiring after their deities and imitating their abominable practices (Devarim 12:29–31). Immediately thereafter comes the absolute insistence on the integrity of the commanded word—neither adding nor subtracting (13:1)—followed by the uncompromising legislation concerning the false prophet or dreamer of dreams, the private enticer (even the closest relative “who is as your own soul”), and the ir ha-nidachat, the city that has been wholly subverted to idolatry.

Parallel to this legislative severity stands the ontological teaching that opens Tanya’s Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 7. The familiar liturgical language—“How goodly is our portion, how pleasant is our lot”—is explained as referring to a unique radiation of the Ein Sof that becomes the exclusive *chelek* and *goral* of the Jew through Torah and mitzvot. This radiation is not a generic share in the divine animation of all worlds; it is a particular, non-rational “lot” drawn down into the soul precisely through the performance of the commandments. The Daily Thought intensifies the same theme by rejecting every form of victimhood: neither people, nor institutions, nor the laws of nature, nor even the Creator’s own demands can be treated as oppressors. The Designer of the cosmos measures the burden according to the hidden powers of the soul in which He Himself is present, and He places His faith in those powers. Hayom Yom of Menachem Av 21 completes the circuit by declaring that activism on behalf of the ways of Chassidus remains a personal obligation even—and especially—while one stands in the marketplace. Whether one’s knowledge is great or limited, the obligation to think of the welfare of others and to draw them toward shiurim and farbrengens is constant.

Tehillim 104 and 105 supply the cosmic and historical horizon: the ordered goodness of creation and the remembered faithfulness of the covenant from Abraham through the Exodus and the Land. Rambam’s Hilchot Kiddush HaChodesh, Chapter 5, adds a further dimension of institutional agency: the human role, under divine command, in sanctifying time through the establishment of the calendar by the court. Together these sources form a coherent architecture of responsibility. Free choice must be actively exercised; a unique divine portion grounds the dignity and capacity of the chooser; the measured demand of the Creator rejects any narrative of victimhood; ordinary commercial and social life remains the arena of obligation; and the

public order requires vigilant protection against internal corrosion. The brit is not merely personal piety. It is the constitutional architecture of a people accountable both to Heaven and to one another.

I. Exegetical Foundations in Parshat Re'eh

The third portion begins with the pedagogical force of historical judgment. After the nations are cut off, Israel is warned against imitation and inquiry into their modes of service (12:30–31). Rashi emphasizes that the destruction itself is a lesson: one must consider why these nations were annihilated—because of the depraved acts they committed—and thereby avoid the same fate. The Torah expands the scope of prohibited worship beyond the standard acts of sacrifice, libation, and prostration to include whatever is the customary mode of service of a particular deity. The warning is therefore not merely against a closed list of rituals but against any assimilation of alien religious logic.

Devarim 13:1 then asserts the integrity of the commanded word itself: "Everything that I command you, you shall be careful to do; you shall neither add to it nor subtract from it." Rashi notes that this equates the "light" commandment with the severe one; the entire structure of mitzvah stands or falls together. The subsequent legislation concerning the false prophet (13:2–6) is deliberately severe. A prophet or dreamer who produces a sign or wonder yet urges the worship of other gods must not be heeded, "for the Lord your G-d is testing you to know whether you love the Lord your G-d with all your heart and with all your soul." Even when the sign materializes, the test remains. The prophet is to be put to death because he has spoken *sarah*—deviation or falsehood—concerning the G-d who redeemed Israel from Egypt. The redemption itself supplies sufficient ground for capital liability.

Ramban on these verses stresses that the signs do not authorize obedience; one is to walk after the Lord alone, fear Him alone, keep His commandments (the Torah of Moshe), heed His voice (legitimate prophets), serve Him, and cleave to Him. The false prophet's wonder is not decisive; the content of the demand is decisive. One may not fear the words of the false prophet because of the sign, nor transgress the service of G-d because of those words.

The private enticer receives even sharper treatment (13:7–12). The list is deliberately intimate: brother (son of the mother), son, daughter, wife of one's bosom, or friend "who is as your own soul." The Torah commands: you shall not love him, you shall not hearken to him, you shall not pity him, you shall not have mercy, you shall not cover up for him. Rather, your hand shall be first against him to put him to death. Rashi underscores that the very closeness of the relationship is the reason for the severity; the emotional bond is precisely what must not be allowed to override loyalty to the brit. The public stoning that follows is meant to deter others: "All Israel shall hear and fear."

The ir ha-nidachat (13:13–19) introduces a different procedural requirement. If a report is heard that unfaithful men have gone forth and led the inhabitants of a city astray, one must inquire, search out, and ask diligently. Only if the matter is established as true is the city to be struck down by the sword, its spoils gathered and burned, and the site left a heap of destruction forever, never to be rebuilt. Ramban explains why the language of thorough inquiry appears here and in the case of an individual idolater, but not with the false prophet or the private mesit: the prophet publicizes himself with signs, and the mesit is known directly to the one he

seeks to entice. The city, by contrast, reaches the authorities by report; therefore diligent inquiry is explicitly required. The law is not hasty. It is rigorous precisely because the stakes are the moral integrity of the entire polity.

These laws are not expressions of cruelty. They are the moral hygiene required to preserve a people whose existence is defined by covenant rather than by blood, sentiment, or private affection. A covenantal society cannot survive if private bonds or charismatic wonder are permitted to override loyalty to the brit. Sentimentality toward the seducer is itself a form of moral abdication.

II. The Unique Portion and Lot in Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh Epistle 7

Tanya approaches the same human being from the opposite direction—the interior of the soul. The liturgical phrase "How goodly is our portion, how pleasant is our lot" is set against the background of the common rabbinic expression "he has no part in the G-d of Israel." Divinity itself is not divisible; yet a particular radiation of the Ein Sof is drawn into the Jewish soul. G-d permeates all worlds yet remains *kadosh*, distinct, not contained in them as the soul is contained in the body. This radiation, as it descends through successive contractions, is generally divided into 613 gradations corresponding to the 613 commandments. These serve as conduits of illumination for the soul, which itself comprises 248 "organs" and 365 "sinews." The principal aim of the descent is for the sake of the soul; all creation exists for man.

The radiation is both a "portion" (a share in the total illumination) and a "lot" (something granted by a transcendent decision that cannot be fully rationalized). Jacob's soul, which contained all the souls of Israel and rectified the sin of Adam, became the vehicle for this manifestation when he called the place El Elohei Yisrael. Thereafter, every Jew who occupies himself with Torah and mitzvot receives a unique configuration of that light. The particular mitzvah for which a given soul feels special affinity intensifies the radiance still further. The teaching therefore grounds personal dignity and capacity in ontology: the powers that the Creator trusts are already present as a distinctive divine allotment. The individual is not a passive recipient of external forces. The individual is the bearer of a unique radiation of the Ein Sof that is actualized through Torah and mitzvot.

III. Cosmic and Historical Horizon: Tehillim 104–105

Psalm 104 is a sustained meditation on the ordered goodness of creation. The Lord wraps Himself in light as a garment; He sets the earth on its foundations so that it shall never be moved; He bounds the waters; He causes grass to grow for the cattle and plants for the service of man; He appoints the moon for seasons and the sun knows its going down. The psalm moves from the grandeur of the cosmic order to the intimate provision for every creature, ending in the call to bless the Lord. Psalm 105 recounts the covenantal history: the covenant with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob; the sojourn in Egypt; the Exodus; the provision in the wilderness; the gift of the Land. Together the two psalms insist that the world in which free choice is exercised is neither chaotic nor indifferent. The same G-d who sets the boundaries of the seas and who remembers His covenant forever is the One who places the measured demand upon the soul. The historical narrative of faithfulness supplies the ground for trust that the present demand is likewise measured and purposeful.

IV. Institutional Agency: Rambam, Hilchot Kiddush HaChodesh Chapter 5

Rambam's fifth chapter of the Laws of the Sanctification of the New Month addresses the authority of the calendar establishment. The court in Eretz Yisrael, through the process of witness testimony and declaration, determines Rosh Chodesh and the festivals. Distant communities, even those within a ten-day journey, rely on the establishment made in the Land; their own calculations do not independently determine the calendar. The chapter underscores that the sanctification of time is a human act performed under divine command and within institutional structures authorized by the Torah. This institutional agency is a further expression of the same principle that runs through Re'eh and Tanya: human beings are not passive spectators of sacred order. They are active participants whose decisions, when aligned with the commanded word, participate in the actualization of that order. The calendar is not merely observed; it is, in a carefully delimited sense, established through human responsibility.

V. Practical and Psychological Dimensions: Hayom Yom and the Daily Thought

Hayom Yom of Menachem Av 21 declares that activism on behalf of the ways of Chassidus means that even when a chassid is in the marketplace, deeply involved in business, he still thinks about what he can do for Chassidic concerns and the welfare of chassidim. When he encounters a business acquaintance he seeks to persuade him to attend shiurim or a farbrengen. This activism is a personal obligation, whether one is great or limited in knowledge of Chassidus. The teaching refuses the excuse of inadequacy. Limited knowledge does not exempt one from the obligation of influence.

The Daily Thought intensifies the interior dimension. The oppressors of which one imagines oneself the victim—people, institutions, the laws of nature—are but tools in the hand of their Master. One is not the victim of the Creator. The Designer does not contrive schemes to undermine His own creations. He knows us as He knows Himself; He sees His world from our eyes; He is our life and our essence. When He makes demands, He meets us on our own ground, measured to the capacity He has hidden within us. There are times when the burden seems impossible relative to the strengths one knows. But He knows better the hidden powers of the soul, and He has faith in them, for He is there within them. The refusal of victimhood is therefore not a psychological technique; it is a theological claim about the presence of the Creator within the measured capacity of the soul.

VI. Thematic Integration

Three themes interlock across the portions. First is the active character of seeing and choosing. Re'eh does not merely present options; it commands the Israelite to *see* the consequences of blessing and curse and to act accordingly. The false prophet's successful sign does not suspend the obligation of discernment; it intensifies the test of love. Second is the unique divine portion. Tanya teaches that the light drawn into the soul through mitzvot is not generic vitality but a specific configuration of the Ein Sof. This undercuts any claim that the individual is a passive recipient of external forces. Third is the refusal of victimhood and the corresponding public vigilance. The Daily Thought insists that the burden is calibrated to hidden capacity. Hayom Yom translates the same conviction into practice in ordinary life. The severity of the laws concerning the enticer and the ir ha-nidachat is the public counterpart of this interior teaching. A covenantal society cannot survive if private bonds or charismatic wonder are permitted to override loyalty to the brit.

VII. Synthesis with Covenantal Republican Thought

The free will that Re'eh places at the center of the human drama is the same free will that classical Jewish political thought and the broader republican tradition recognize as the necessary foundation of self-government. A people that cannot choose blessing over curse cannot sustain ordered liberty. Philip Pettit's conception of freedom as non-domination—freedom from the arbitrary power of another, even the unexercised power—finds a theological counterpart in the Torah's insistence that no human bond, however intimate, and no charismatic claim, however wondrous, may dominate the individual's allegiance to the covenant. The demand to uproot the ir ha-nidachat mirrors the republican insistence on civic virtue and vigilance against corruption, whether that corruption appears in the form of demagogues or systemic moral failure inside the polity.

Tanya's teaching that each soul receives a unique Divine portion supplies the theocentric counterpart to the republican emphasis on the dignity of the individual under higher law. The individual is not merely a rights-bearing atom; the individual is the bearer of a distinctive radiation of the Ein Sof actualized through Torah and mitzvot. This ontological grounding prevents the republican ideal of non-domination from collapsing into either radical individualism or majoritarian tyranny. Hayom Yom's call to active influence even in ordinary commercial life is the daily practice of citizenship: the private person remains responsible for the moral health of the public square.

Eric Nelson's recovery of the "Hebrew Republic" tradition in early modern political thought underscores the same point. Seventeenth-century Christian Hebraists, reading the biblical polity through rabbinic lenses, came to regard the Hebrew Bible as a political constitution designed by G-d. This encounter contributed to republican exclusivism (the claim that republican government alone is legitimate), to arguments for certain forms of redistribution, and to early formulations of religious toleration. The Torah's legislation against internal subversion is therefore not an embarrassment to be explained away; it is an early and rigorous statement of the principle that a free people must defend the conditions of its own freedom. The brit is not merely personal piety; it is the constitutional architecture of a free people who know they are accountable both to Heaven and to one another.

VIII. Critical Reflections

The synthesis is not without tension. Secular republicanism can slide toward a closed immanence in which the only remaining standard is the will of the majority or the procedures of the state. Theological grounding in Divine sovereignty and the unique portion of the soul prevents that collapse. Conversely, a purely pietistic reading of the Torah can treat the political demands of Re'eh as archaic and irrelevant to modern life. The daily portions refuse both reductions. The severity of the laws concerning the enticer and the city is the necessary counterpart of the interior teaching of unique portion and measured capacity. Without the public vigilance, the private dignity becomes privatized and ultimately impotent; without the ontological grounding, the public vigilance becomes mere coercion.

Further, the requirement of thorough inquiry in the case of the ir ha-nidachat models a procedural seriousness that guards against hasty or partisan application. The law is not a license for unexamined zeal; it is a demand for rigorous establishment of fact before decisive action. This procedural care itself is part of the moral architecture.

X. Conclusion

The portions of Av 21 converge on a single imperative: see, choose, and act from the unique portion already allotted. The false prophet's wonder does not suspend the test of love. The closest relative's secret enticement does not suspend the duty of loyalty. The apparent disproportion between burden and known strength does not suspend the Creator's measured demand. The ordinary preoccupations of the marketplace do not suspend the obligation to influence others. And the institutional task of sanctifying time does not suspend the human responsibility to establish, under divine command, the order of sacred time.

In the language of the Daily Thought: He knows better the hidden powers of the soul, and He has faith in them, for He is there within them. The task is to act upon that faith—personally, publicly, and without the abdication of victimhood.

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